

President Nasser waves to the cheering crowd after announcing that he had nationalised the Suez Canal in July 1956.

Key term

Charisma
The capacity to inspire devotion in others, as if endowed with superhuman or, at least, exceptional powers.

Nasser's name was chanted and Arab governments came under huge pressure to bring their policies into line with Egypt. Syria and Saudi Arabia broke off relations with Britain and France while Jordan signed a military pact with Syria and Egypt. In January 1957, a 'Treaty of Arab Solidarity' was signed by Egypt, Syria, Jordan and Saudi Arabia.

Nasser's **charisma**, his perceived victory over Suez and the predominance of Cairo radio contributed to an ever-rising tide of Arab nationalism. This reached its height, in 1958, when Syria demanded a complete merger with Egypt so as to form one state.

Summary diagram: The growth of Arab nationalism

Arab nationalism

Grew in response to Western domination which was shown in:

- mandates in inter-war years
- creation of the state of Israel on Arab land
- continued presence of British troops on Egyptian territory
- pressure to join anti-Soviet alliance such as Baghdad Pact

President Nasser became champion of Arabs in defying the West:

- in his use of Cairo Radio
- in Czech arms deal 1955
- in Suez crisis 1956